

Lesson 1: Are You Ready For God to Work Through You?

Key Scripture: 2 Chronicles 16:9

Teaching

In 1886, at a summer Bible conference in Northfield, Massachusetts, a movement called the Student Volunteer Movement began that would influence thousands of college students toward missionary service.

Influenced by special prayer meetings, education about the needs of the world, preaching, and radical examples of sacrificial living, college campuses in America and England ignited with missionary fervor.

Key to the movement was an emphasis on educating Christians about the needs of the world and their role in missions.

For example, a group of students at Princeton University started the Princeton Foreign Missionary Society whose object was "*the cultivation of a missionary spirit among the students of the College, the information of its members on all subjects of missionary interest, and especially the leading of men to consecrate to foreign missions work.*"

The same basic purpose is behind these World Christian Lessons: to help Christians understand the spiritual needs of the world and discover the role Christ wants them to have in it.

One of the leaders of the Student Volunteer Movement, John Mott, had this to say about the role each believer can play in missions:

"It is possible for the most obscure person in a church, with a heart right toward God, to exercise as much power for the evangelization of the world, as it is for those who stand in the most prominent positions." (Mott, John R. *The Pastor and Modern Missions*, p. 203).

Through simple steps of obedience, God can use each believer to influence the course of history and make an eternal difference.

Consider 2 Chronicles 16:9:

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to shew himself strong in the behalf of them whose heart is perfect toward him..."

God is still looking for people through whom He can show Himself strong.

Closing Challenge

Do you believe that God can work powerfully through your life to reach the world with the gospel just like He worked through others in the past?

Are you willing to yield your heart to the Lord so that He might use you for His purposes?

Truth to Remember: God does extraordinary things through ordinary people who give their lives to Him.

Lesson 2: Why Should We Care About the World?

Key Scripture: Luke 19:10

Opening Question: Why is missions important?

Teaching

The work of reaching the world with the gospel of Jesus Christ requires churches and missionaries to make significant sacrifices.

Without a bigger “*why*,” we will not be willing to consistently make the necessary sacrifices.

In Luke 19:10, describing the reason He came, Jesus says: “For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.”

The desire of God for all people everywhere to know and worship Him runs through the entire Bible.

- From the way God sought and provided a covering for the first sinners in Genesis 3, to the promise of blessing for “all families of the earth” through Abraham in Genesis 12:3, to the prayer of David for God’s saving health to be known “among all nations” in Psalm 67 it is clear that God’s heart is for all people everywhere to know Him.
- The love of God for the world is what caused Him to give His only begotten Son to die on the cross for the sins of the whole world (John 3:16). It is also what caused Him to command the church to go into all the world and preach the gospel to every person (Mark 16:15).
- The Bible concludes with a vast multitude of redeemed people from every nation and language standing before the throne of God praising Him for His salvation (Revelation 7:9-10).

If God cares this much for the world, then we who love Him should love what He loves.

- Missions should matter to us because the world matters to God.
- A “world Christian” – not a worldly Christian – is someone whose heart is increasingly becoming aligned with God's heart for the world. The purpose of these lessons is to help cultivate that kind of heart in each of us.

Closing Challenge

What do we really care about?

What consumes our thoughts, time, resources, and actions?

Let’s ask God to help us love what He loves and care about what He cares about.

Truth to Remember: God's heart is for the world, and He wants His heart to become ours.

Lesson 3: What Will Happen If We Don't Share the Gospel?

Key Scripture: Matthew 9:36–38

Opening Question: When Jesus looked at the crowds around Him, what did He see that others failed to see?

Teaching

Jesus was “moved with compassion on them, because they fainted, and were scattered abroad, as sheep having no shepherd” (Matthew 9:36).

- He saw their weariness and exhaustion.
- He saw their lost condition and the fact that they had no one to care for them or guide them.

Jesus saw the true spiritual reality of people: We are all sinners, and without Christ, we are lost.

Romans 3:10-18 puts it this way:

“10 As it is written, There is none righteous, no, not one: 11 There is none that understandeth, there is none that seeketh after God. 12 They are all gone out of the way, they are together become unprofitable; there is none that doeth good, no, not one. 13 Their throat is an open sepulchre; with their tongues they have used deceit; the poison of asps is under their lips: 14 Whose mouth is full of cursing and bitterness: 15 Their feet are swift to shed blood: 16 Destruction and misery are in their ways: 17 And the way of peace have they not known: 18 There is no fear of God before their eyes.”

In addition, Romans 3:19-20 explains that there is nothing any person can do to make themselves good:

“19 Now we know that what things soever the law saith, it saith to them who are under the law: that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may become guilty before God. 20 Therefore by the deeds of the law there shall no flesh be justified in his sight: for by the law is the knowledge of sin.”

The fact that mankind is hopelessly lost apart from Christ is what makes the gospel such good news.

It is also what causes Jesus to care so deeply and should cause us to be willing to do what Jesus told His disciples to do in Matthew 9:37-38:

- Pray for laborers for the needy harvest fields of the world.

Closing Challenge

How do we currently view the people around us?

How does a biblical perspective of mankind's condition impact our concern for the lost?

Choose one person and pray for his or her salvation. Choose a country and pray for laborers.

Truth to remember: People are not okay. Without Christ, they are lost and perishing.

Lesson 4: Why Have They Not Heard?

Key Scripture: Romans 10:13–15

Opening Question: If the gospel is the greatest news in all the world, then why have so many people still not heard it?

Teaching

Romans 10 gives us a simple chain:

- People must **call** upon the Lord to be saved.
- But before they can call, they must **believe**.
- Before they can believe, they must **hear**.
- And before they can hear, someone must **preach the gospel to them and be sent**.

That leads to an uncomfortable conclusion: If some have not heard the gospel, then we are responsible.

Consider what Paul said to the church at Corinth:

*“Awake to righteousness, and sin not; for **some have not the knowledge of God: I speak this to your shame.**” (1 Corinthians 15:34).*

Creation tells people there is a Creator. Romans 1 teaches that God’s power and Godhead are revealed through what He has made.

Conscience also bears witness that there is right and wrong.

But creation and the conscience cannot explain the gospel.

The gospel must be communicated, and God has entrusted the responsibility of communicating it to His church.

2 Corinthians 5:18-20 explains:

*“18 And all things are of God, who hath reconciled us to himself by Jesus Christ, and hath **given to us the ministry of reconciliation**; 19 To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them; and hath **committed unto us the word of reconciliation**. 20 Now then **we are ambassadors for Christ**, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ’s stead, be ye reconciled to God.”*

Closing Challenge

How personally do you take the work of telling the world about Jesus?

What are you doing to make sure that all have heard?

Who in your life could you seek to share the gospel with this week?

Truth to Remember: If people are going to hear the gospel, someone who already knows it must tell them.

Lesson 5: Who Is Called To Go?

Key Scripture: Isaiah 6:8

Opening Question: Do we need a special call from God to preach the gospel?

Teaching

The Bible uses the word “call” and “called” to refer to all saved people (Romans 1:6; 1 Corinthians 1:2) and to many responsibilities that from from our relationship with Christ:

- Holiness (1 Thessalonians 4:7; 1 Peter 1:15)
- Peace (Colossians 3:15)
- Good works (Ephesians 2:10; 4:1)
- A life of self-denial and complete surrender to Christ (Luke 9:23-24; Romans 12:1-2)
- Proclaiming the gospel and teaching all nations (Mark 16:15; Matthew 28:19-20)

All believers, therefore are “the called” and have a general call on their lives to actively follow Christ and carry out the Great Commission.

Some believers may be led by the Lord and send by their church to serve as missionaries. But the fact that God gifts some to serve as missionaries does not exempt all Christians from obeying the clear commands of Scripture.

Robert Speer expressed it like this:

“There is a general obligation resting upon Christians to see that the Gospel of Jesus Christ is preached to the world. You and I need no special call to apply that general call of God to our lives. We do need a special call to exempt us from its application to our lives. In other words, every one of us stands under a presumptive obligation to give his life to the world unless we have some special exemption.”

When it comes to world evangelism, every believer is commanded to be involved. What we need the Lord’s guidance for is where and how He wants us personally to participate.

Perhaps, like Isaiah, as we consider the Lord’s heart for the nations, we would even be willing to say, “Here am I, send me.” Those who serve as missionaries should have confirmation from the Word of God and their church, but every Christian’s “default setting” should be *go* not *stay*!

Closing Challenge

Have you ever used the “‘I’m not called’ excuse” to keep you from obeying the clear commands of Scripture?

What would keep you from volunteering for missionary service?

Truth to Remember: You don't need a special call to obey a clear command.

Lesson 6: What Difference Can One Person Make?

Key Scripture: 1 Samuel 17:45–47

Opening Question: Can one ordinary person really make a difference in reaching the world?

Teaching

Throughout Scripture, God repeatedly used individuals who were willing to trust Him.

- Abraham permanently left home without knowing exactly where he was going.
- Gideon faced an overwhelming enemy.
- David walked onto a battlefield when an entire army was afraid.
- Elijah stood against hundreds of false prophets.
- Paul entered cities where Christ was virtually unknown.

The thing these individuals had in common was their willingness to trust and obey God. God's strength and power enabled them to do extraordinary things.

Notice what David said in 1 Samuel 17:

"I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts..." (v.45)

"the battle is the LORD's..." (v.47)

The question shouldn't be: "What can one person accomplish?"

Instead, we should ask, "What can God accomplish through one surrendered person?"

Jesus modeled the power of God to multiply the efforts of one.

- He invested in the twelve disciples.
- They reached others and taught them to teach others.
- And the gospel went into the whole world (Colossians 1:5-6).

If we will do we can, with the Lord's help, to pray, give, witness, and disciple, the Lord can multiply our efforts in a way that brings Him glory.

Closing Challenge

Ask yourself: "Who is one person I can influence for Christ right now?"

Pray for that person by name and take one step toward investing in them.

Truth to remember: Never underestimate what God can do through one obedient life.

Lesson 7: How Do We Reach the Whole World?

Key Scripture: 2 Timothy 2:2

Opening Question: What would happen if, every year, every Christian taught one other person to follow Jesus?

Teaching

In 2 Timothy 2:2, we find four generations of disciples: Paul → Timothy → Faithful Men → Others Also

Paul taught Timothy, who was expected to teach faithful men, who would then teach others also.

Like a relay race, each person was to receive the truth and pass it on to the next person.

This process of teaching others to know, follow, and obey Christ is called “discipleship.”

Discipleship is at the heart of the Great Commission. Jesus said:

Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world. Amen.”
(Matthew 28:19-20)

- We are commanded to “teach all nations.”
- Then we are told to baptize those who have been taught in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.
- Additionally, we are to teach those who are baptized to obey all that Christ commanded.

The way we disciple is by:

1. Being discipled and taught ourselves.
2. Studying the Word of God so that we can know what to teach.
3. Helping those we teach to take steps of obedience, including baptism, church membership, and discipling others.

While discipleship often involves teaching Bible lessons, it is far more than a series of lessons. It involves modeling the Christian life. It happens as we spend time together. And it should always move people toward greater obedience to Christ.

Closing Challenge

Are people around you getting closer to Jesus or farther away as a result of your influence?

Who can you teach what you have been taught from God’s Word?

Pray that God would give you someone you can teach.

Prioritize those who are faithful and able to teach others.

Truth to remember: Discipleship is the key method for reaching the world with the gospel.

Lesson 8: How Do We Fund the Mission?

Key Scripture: 1 Corinthians 8:1-9

Opening Question: Where does the money for missions come from?

Teaching

The Apollo space program, which resulted in putting a man on the moon, cost \$25.8 billion, which is equivalent to over \$300 billion in today's money.

Like the mission to the moon, the mission of evangelizing the world in our generation requires significant financial resources.

So, where does the money for missions come from?

2 Corinthians 8 introduces us to the church of Macedonia, which was very instrumental in furthering the mission of the Apostle Paul.

- v.2 They were not wealthy, but they were generous.
- v.3 They gave beyond what seemed possible for them.
- v.4 They had a deep desire to get participate in the work through giving.
- v.5 Their generosity stemmed from the fact that they had first given themselves to the Lord.
- v.7 Their example should motivate us to grow in this area of Christian maturity.
- v.9 Christ Himself modeled the greatest measure of generosity when He gave us His riches for us.

We, as God's children, have the privilege to be involved in the Lord's work through our giving. Philippians 4:10-2- gives us further insight into how God uses His people to support His work:

- v.10 We should give not to simply to meet needs but to invest in eternity.
- v.17 As we give, we lay up treasure in heaven and will receive eternal rewards.
- v.18-20 Offerings we make for missions are well pleasing and glorifying to God.

Closing Challenge

The greatest return on investment is the Lord's work.

How much do you have invested in eternity?

Would you pray about what God might have you give, above and beyond your normal giving, for missions?

Truth to remember: All that is needed to fund the mission is already in the hands of God's people.

Lesson 9: How Do We Get & Keep A Burden For the Lost?

Key Scripture: Romans 9:1-3

Opening Question: What does it mean to have a burden for the lost?

Teaching

The Apostle Paul makes a shocking statement in Roman 9:3.

- He says that he wishes that he could be cursed if it would mean Israel would be saved!
- The reason he says this is found in Romans 9:2 - his "great heaviness" and "continual sorrow."
- Paul genuinely loved his countrymen and was longed deeply to see them saved.
- His concern for their lost condition were like a heavy burden of grief and pain.

This kind of concern for the lost is something that we admire but often struggle to experience and maintain ourselves.

So how can we develop a greater burden for the lost?

1. Spend time with God in His Word so that you continually gain His perspective and develop His compassion (Matthew 9:36).
2. Learn about the needs of the world and pray for laborers (Matthew 9:37-38). (Use the thecountryoftheweek.com and operationworld.org to fuel a burden.)
3. Seek to get your eyes off of yourself and your own needs (John 4:35).
4. Attend church services where missionaries present the needs of their countries.
5. Subscribe to missionary prayer letters via email or the Church Center App.
6. Go on a missions trip to see the needs firsthand.
7. "Adopt" a missionary and become a "yokefellow" who strives together in prayer with that missionary in prayer (Romans 15:30).

A burden grows when we intentionally expose our hearts to the needs of people and bring those needs before God.

But ultimately, we maintain a burden by remaining close to Christ. The closer we walk with Him, the more His concerns become our concerns.

Closing Challenge

What keeps you from having great heaviness and continual sorrow for the lost?

What could you begin doing regularly to keep the needs of lost people before your heart?

Truth to Remember: We get a burden by seeing the need, but we keep our burden by staying close to Christ.

Lesson 10: Where Do We Fit?

Key Scripture: 1 Corinthians 12:4-7

Opening Question: How do we find where we fit in the mission of the church?

Teaching

Though the work of reaching the world with the gospel was given to every believer, each believer will carry out the mission in unique ways according to how God has gifted them.

1 Corinthians 12:1-11 teaches us several important things about spiritual gifts:

- v.3 Every saved person has the Holy Spirit.
- v.4-6 Our gifts may be different, but it is the same God who is at work in all of us.
- v.7-11 Every single believer profits from the gifting of the Spirit and has something to contribute to work of God.¹

So, how do we find where we fit in God's mission?

1. **Present yourself to God (Romans 12:1).** God calls us to yield ourselves completely to Him, willing to serve Him however and wherever He chooses. This type of total surrender is completely "reasonable" when we consider the "mercies of God."
2. **Don't be conformed to the world (Romans 12:2).** The world's values and priorities are inconsistent with love for God. As long as the world is pressing us into its mold, we will struggle to see and fulfill God's purpose for our lives.
3. **Renew your mind (Romans 12:2).** The lies of the world are counteracted by the truth of God's Word, which helps us to think correctly about God, ourselves, the world, and eternity.
4. **Begin humbly serving in your local church, under the guidance of those gifted to equip you for ministry (Romans 12:3-8; Ephesians 4:11-12).** As we serve, we will discover our gifts and find our place in world evangelism.
5. **Assume your ministry will have a missions emphasis.** Because the mission of the church is to reach the whole world, each ministry of the church should contribute to world evangelism.

Closing Challenge

How willing are you to use your gifts, resources, and time to serve the Lord however and wherever He may want to use you?

Take some time to study the various individuals God used in missions work in the book of Acts. Consider their backgrounds, occupations, and contributions.

¹ The list of spiritual gifts seen here and in other places (Ephesians 4:11; Romans 12:6-8) seem to be broad categories of gifts, with some of these gifts passing away and each of us having our own unique combination.

Truth to Remember: Every Christian has a place in God's plan to reach the world.